Asia. Over time, promotion of democracy and expansion of trade networks were added to the core set of US goals.

America's current forward-based posture and alliance network in the Indo-Pacific is a legacy of its success in achieving that postwar goal. Yet it is also true that Washington did not face a significant challenger for dominance in Asia during the Cold War. This is not to say, of course, that there were no challenges at all to American policy and goals during those decades. Although a secondary theater for the Soviet Union, Asia saw a great deal of Soviet activity and attempted subversion of regional governments, but Moscow was never able to bring major power to bear in a way that could have defeated US forces or taken over significant amounts of territory. Similarly, China during the Cold War was internally focused, veering from consolidation after the Chinese Communist Party victory in 1949 to Mao's domestically destructive policies like the Great Leap Forward and the Cultural Revolution. India, too, during these decades hewed to a Nehruvian nonalignment policy and put much of its energies into leading the global nonaligned bloc. Japan, the region's erstwhile great power, poured its energies into domestic production and settled into a subordinate role as Washington's key Asian ally. Despite fighting brutal and domestically divisive wars in Korea and Vietnam, the United States was never forced to defend its position in Asia the way it was in Europe.

In other words, it is not misleading to conclude that for half a century after World War II, strategy in Asia was relatively easy for Washington. Not so today. In the case of China particularly, Washington confronts the difficulty of dealing with a "near-peer" competitor whose goals are increasingly antithetical to its own.

The Chinese challenge does not obviate seven decades of US strategy, but it mandates that policy be tailored to protect core American interests. Washington can neither surrender its alliances and interests nor undertake a chimerical attempt to freeze the Indo-Pacific in place. Overreach is a natural temptation in a region as large as the Indo-Pacific, as is the converse, a fatalism that engenders a timidity preventing the adoption of clear goals, the formation of a realistic strategy, and